



Detector dog video

Supporting detector dog operations through technical expertise.

Behind Australia's biosecurity detector dog teams are dedicated Technical Supervisors. They support handler training and development, oversee the health and wellbeing of detector dogs, and work with operational areas to ensure detector dog teams are deployed where they can have the greatest impact.

Learn more about our detector dog teams

- [Hear from Australian Chief Veterinary Officer about the vital role of biosecurity detector dog teams](#) - 1 May 2026
- [Meet Australia's 2025 Biosecurity Top Dog](#) - 17 April 2026
- [Inside the world of DAFF biosecurity detector dog handlers](#) - 27 January 2026
- [Dedication first on the frontline of our border](#) - 23 December 2025
- [Newly trained detector dogs boost Australia's biosecurity frontline](#) - 22 December 2025
- [Detect and protect podcast series](#) - 2021 to 2023

Our detector dog teams are one of our most effective frontline tools. They help stop exotic pests and diseases from entering Australia.

Our biosecurity detector dog program is a national capability built around skilled detector dog teams. Each team is made up of a trained detector dog and its handler. These teams work at airports, seaports and mail centres across Australia. They screen travellers, cargo and mail for biosecurity risk material.

Dogs use their strong detection skills, while handlers guide the search, assess risk and interpret dog behaviour. This partnership makes the teams fast, accurate and adaptable in many biosecurity environments.

The detector dog program supports every stage of a detector dog team's career, including:

- choosing and training the dogs
- recruiting and developing handlers
- operations and capability improvement
- welfare, wellbeing and retirement
- ongoing innovation to strengthen detection work.

Handlers, dogs, trainers, technical supervisors and program partners all work together as a national capability. Their combined work helps keep Australia's agriculture, environment and communities safe.

Biosecurity detector dogs

Biosecurity detector dogs are one of the most effective tools in Australia's biosecurity system. Their strong sense of smell and natural drive to search help stop exotic pests and diseases from entering the country.

Once trained, detector dogs can find many types of biosecurity risk material. This includes meat, fresh produce, seeds and plant material. Their speed and accuracy let them screen large numbers of travellers, mail and cargo. They also adapt well to complex and busy environments.

Detector dogs work as part of a detector dog team. They rely on their handler to guide searches, read their behaviour and support their ongoing training and welfare.

Potential detector dogs come from the [Australian Border Force \(ABF\) detector dog breeding program](#). Puppies usually begin formal biosecurity training at 12–18 months of age.

Labradors are chosen because they are calm, co-operative and eager to work. They have strong hunt, food and retrieve drives, which make search work enjoyable for them. Their size and agility also make it easier for them to move through the screening areas they work in.

Selection helps ensure only dogs with the right temperament, health and natural drive progress to training.

Once selected, dogs start formal training at the national training facility in Brisbane. They learn to detect a range of biosecurity risk materials and to work with focus in different biosecurity environments.

Training builds consistent search skills and reinforces motivation. Trainers check each dog's health and performance throughout the program. Dogs that meet the program's standards are then paired with experienced handlers. They are deployed to airports, seaports and mail centres across Australia.

Biosecurity detector dog training program

The detector dog training program runs for 8 weeks and is delivered by expert trainers at the national training facility.

Dogs train in a variety of scenarios to help them detect biosecurity risk material such as meat, fresh fruit, seeds and plants. They learn to link each target odour with a reward, such as food, a game or a pat.

Trainers regularly assess each dog's health, eagerness to search and performance in different environments. These checks continue throughout the dog's career. Some novice dogs do not progress and are returned to the ABF. Dogs that graduate are paired with handlers and begin two months of transitional training in the workplace. This helps them build confidence and capability before working on their own.

Detector dogs are trained to find biosecurity risk items that could bring pests or diseases into Australia. Over their working life, a detector dog may find up to 9,000 biosecurity risk items. The most common are meat, seeds and fruit.

When dogs find undeclared goods carried by travellers, penalties may apply. Travellers should [check what they can bring into Australia and what they must declare](#).

We continue to innovate and modernise our detector dog capabilities to strengthen our biosecurity system.

Retiring

Detector dogs usually work until around 8 years of age. When they retire, they are placed into loving homes, often with one of their handlers.

Biosecurity detector dog handlers

Every successful detection begins with the strong partnership between a detector dog and its handler. Our handlers are highly trained biosecurity professionals who combine their handler skills and biosecurity knowledge in risk assessment and operational decision-making.

Handlers guide and interpret their dog's work, undertake daily training, manage the dog's welfare and engage with the public in complex operational environments. They are essential to the program's effectiveness, professionalism and reputation, helping ensure Australia remains free from harmful pests and diseases.

When detector dog handler roles are advertised, candidates must complete a written application and interview designed to test for desired capabilities, experience and attitude. Shortlisted applicants then complete a practical assessment designed to test their suitability. The assessment looks at:

- canine interaction, confidence and coordination
- problem solving and critical thinking
- ability to follow instructions and respond to feedback
- communication and engagement with dogs
- trainability, resilience and self-assessment skills.

Candidates must also complete a medical and fitness check and obtain an Australian Federal Police security clearance.

Becoming a detector dog handler involves a structured development program.

Biosecurity detector dog handler development program

Our dog handlers undertake a 12-week development program in 4 stages.

Stage 1: Introduction

Trainee handlers shadow an existing detector dog team to learn about daily duties. They complete online and practical training on animal welfare and basic operational tasks.

Stage 2: Intensive practical training

Trainee handlers attend the national training facility in Brisbane. They learn dog-training principles and biosecurity detection skills in simulated operational environments.

Stage 3: On-the-job training

Trainee handlers work in busy operational locations with experienced detector dogs to build confidence and practical skills.

Stage 4: Advanced training

Handlers continue on-the-job learning, focusing on advanced problem-solving and handling skills. All handlers complete verification exercises, just like their dogs.

Additionally, detector dog handlers are required to successfully complete mandatory biosecurity foundation and pathway training.

Detector dog handlers play an important role in keeping Australia safe from biosecurity risks. They care for detector dogs and make sure they stay healthy and ready to screen travellers, mail and cargo. Handlers are trained biosecurity officers and apply biosecurity knowledge in their daily work. Handlers run regular maintenance training sessions so that dogs stay effective in their work while also maintaining their own handling skills.

Detector dog handlers play a key role in protecting Australia's biosecurity. Their work is varied, combining animal care, operational duties and ongoing professional development.

Handlers are responsible for:

- maintaining their detector dog's health, wellbeing and readiness for duty
- screening travellers, cargo and mail for biosecurity risks
- conducting regular training to ensure dogs remain effective and motivated
- communicating with the public about biosecurity requirements
- maintaining their own skills through verification exercises and maintenance training.

A handler's career involves continual learning and development. As they gain experience, many go on to mentor new handlers, support regional operations or contribute to capability development across the program.

Other program support

The Biosecurity Detector Dog Program relies on a wide network of skilled people:

- Trainers – train novice dogs and handlers and improve training methods.
- Technical supervisors – provide operational support, training and national performance guidance.
- Operational managers – lead, manage and deploy detector dog teams in operational activities and environments.
- Kennel supervisors – manage kennelling, enrichment, safe transport and daily welfare needs.
- Capability managers – guide deployment and run verification activities.
- Policy officers – develop policies that support all functions of the program.
- Departmental scientists – provide advice on emerging biosecurity risks.
- Government partners – work with us on breeding, selection, deployment and risk management, including the Australian Border Force.

Together, these people form a national capability that protects Australia's biosecurity and supports the long-term success of our detector dog program.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/australia/detector-dogs>